

Greater bulldog bat

Noctilio leporinus

- ↔ 2½–3 in (6–8 cm)
- 📍 Central America, N., E., and C. South America
- ⊗ Common

Remarkably, this tropical American bat is a specialist at catching fish. It targets them at night using echolocation to detect leaping fish and the ripples they make, then scoops them from the water with its sharp-clawed back feet. It can catch fiddler crabs and shrimp in the same way, but also takes insects and even scorpions. It has velvety fur with a distinct pale stripe along the middle of its back.

Common pipistrelle

Pipistrellus pipistrellus

- ↔ 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)
- 📍 Europe to N. Africa, W., and C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

One of the most widespread Eurasian bats, this small insect-eater lives in a range of habitats from dense forests to city parks and suburban yards. It can squeeze its tiny body into the narrowest crevices, slipping between overlapping tiles to roost by day in roof spaces, and is one of the first bats to emerge at dusk to prey on midges, small moths, and other flying insects. It hibernates throughout the winter and forms



large breeding colonies of up to 1,000 females, each nursing a single baby.

Pallid bat

Antrozous pallidus

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–8 cm)
- 📍 W. North America to Mexico, Cuba
- ⊗ Common

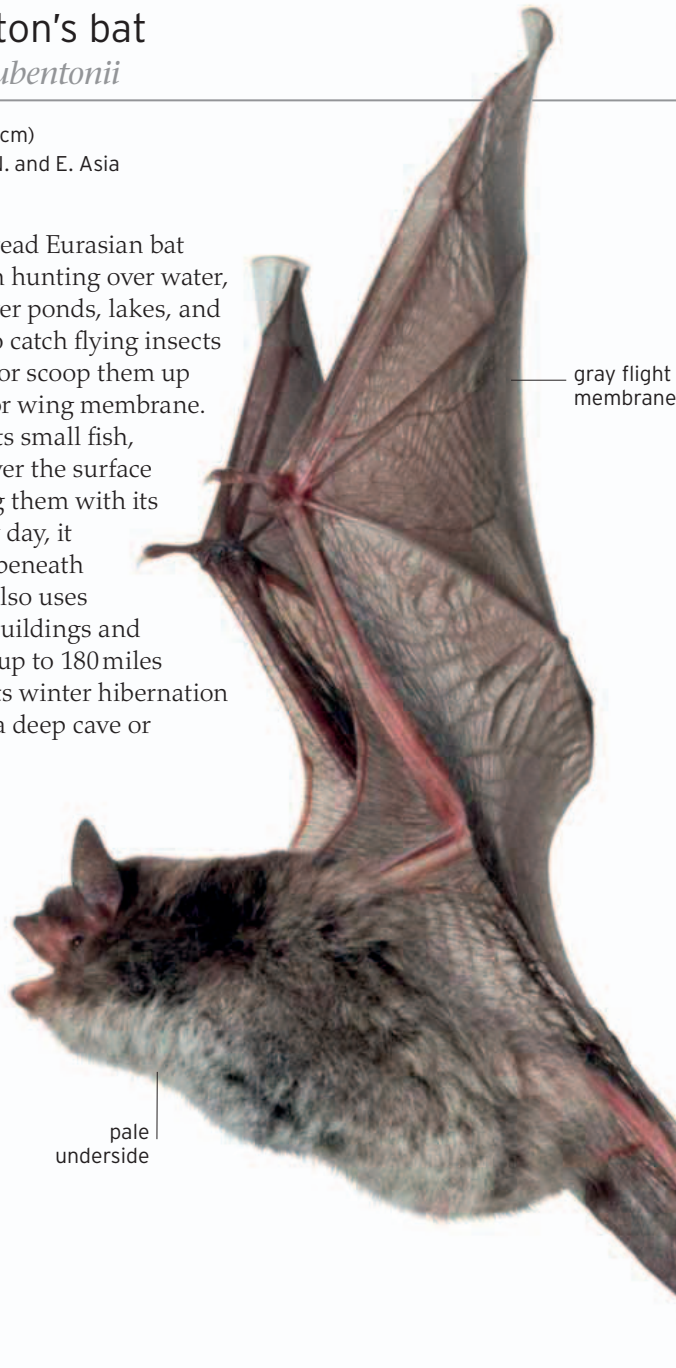
The pallid bat lives in arid habitats, where it hunts on the ground at night, flying low and using its eyes and ears. It targets large insects, spiders, centipedes, scorpions, and even lizards and mice, swooping down to seize them and carry them off to a favorite perch where it can eat them. By day, the bats gather in groups and retreat to roost in rock crevices, old buildings, and tree cavities, giving clearly audible cries as they go.

Daubenton's bat

Myotis daubentonii

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–8 cm)
- 📍 Europe to N. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This widespread Eurasian bat specializes in hunting over water, flying low over ponds, lakes, and waterways to catch flying insects in its mouth or scoop them up with its tail or wing membrane. It even targets small fish, skimming over the surface and grabbing them with its large feet. By day, it often roosts beneath bridges but also uses abandoned buildings and trees. It flies up to 180 miles (300 km) to its winter hibernation site, usually a deep cave or an old mine.



Brown long-eared bat

Plecotus auritus

- ↔ 1½–2 in (4–5 cm)
- 📍 Europe, C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The enormous ears of this small woodland bat—almost as long as its body—give it incredibly sensitive hearing. They allow it to detect the faint sounds made by insects such as moths and beetles as they feed on vegetation at night, so it can pick them off the leaves. It then usually takes its prey to a perch to eat. It roosts in caves, trees, and outbuildings and spends the winter hibernating in a deep cave, abandoned mine, or disused basement or cellar.

Common noctule

Nyctalus noctula

- ↔ 3 in (8 cm)
- 📍 Europe to W., E., and S. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This high-flying bat lives in woodland, roosting alone in tree cavities by day. At night it hunts by swooping down on insects such as large moths. It hibernates in groups in better-insulated places, such as caves, and may travel 1,200 miles (2,000 km) or more to find a suitable site, returning in spring.



Angolan free-tailed bat

Mops condylurus

- ↔ 3 in (8 cm)
- 📍 W., C., E., and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

Named for its long, mouselike tail, which is not attached to any flight membranes, the Angolan free-tailed bat is widespread across Africa south of the Sahara. It gathers in large numbers to roost by day, emerging each evening in noisy, flapping groups

designed to confuse potential predators such as hawks and owls. It preys on flying insects, discarding the hardest, most inedible parts as it eats them on the wing.

Other species

- **Large flying fox**
Pteropus vampyrus » p294
- **Lesser short-tailed bat**
Mystacina tuberculata » p355
- **Vampire bat**
Desmodus rotundus » p115
- **White bat**
Ectophylla alba » p79